

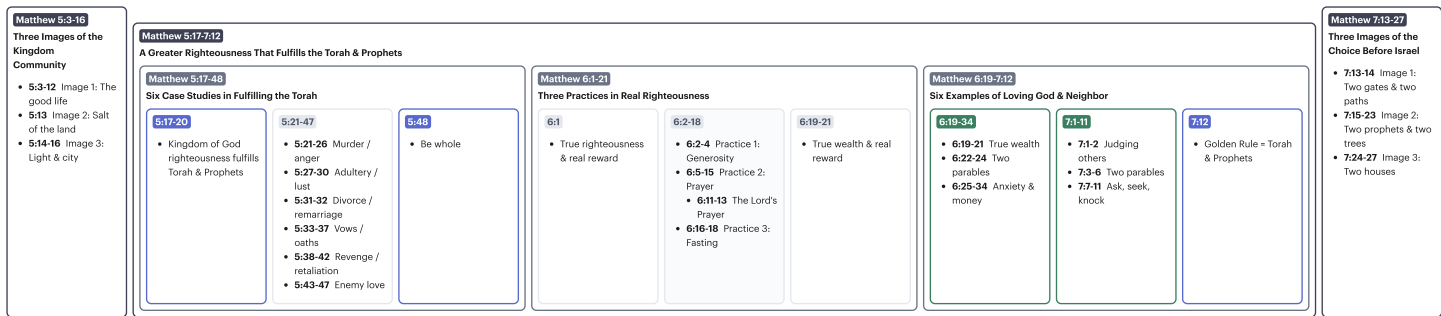
Session 13: Generosity, Prayer, and Fasting

Key Takeaways

- The Greek word *hupokrites*, from which we derive the word “hypocrite,” is the word for a “stage actor.”
- In an imagination shaped by the Hebrew Bible, generosity is about how we relate to God just as much as prayer or fasting is.
- Jesus teaches wisdom in evaluating our motives to assess whether or not our good deeds are done so that others can see.

Righteousness & Religious Practices

As we come to Matthew 6:1-18, we step into the second part of the central movement of the Sermon on the Mount. Notice that in the entire stretch of the sermon from 5:1-7:29, this section of 6:1-21 makes up the center of the center.



Matthew 5:3-7:27. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Jesus has just described the relationship of his Kingdom of God ethic to God’s revelation in the Torah (5:17-48). Jesus’ main point was that his teaching does not replace or counter God’s will revealed in the Torah. Rather, it fulfills God’s will and the entire storyline of the Torah and Prophets. In 5:17-48, Jesus showed how “greater righteousness” requires us to reimagine all of our relationships to other people. As we turn to 6:1-18, Jesus begins describing righteousness as the way that we do right by God, that is, how his followers are to express this “greater righteousness” to God. The relationship between 5:17-48 and 6:1-18 could then depicted in the following way.

Matthew 5:20

"If your **righteousness** does not surpass the scribes and the Pharisees, you won't be entering the kingdom of the skies.

Matthew 5:21-48

6 case studies where **righteousness** = doing right by other people

Anger / Sex / Divorce
Truth-telling / Injustice / Enemy Love

Matthew 6:1-21

3 case studies where **righteousness** = doing right by God

Generosity / Prayer / Fasting

Righteousness and Religious Practices. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

The larger block of Matthew 6:1-21 itself has a three-part flow: It begins with a three-line thesis statement that is illustrated with three case studies, followed by a three-part conclusion.

Matthew 6:1

Thesis Statement

- Be careful, that you don't do your righteousness in front of people, for the purpose of being seen by them.
If you do, you will have no **reward** from **your Father in the skies**.

Matthew 6:2-4

Generous Giving to Those in Need

- and **your Father** ... he will fully **reward** you.

Matthew 6:5-15

Prayer

- and **your Father** ... he will fully **reward** you.

Matthew 6:16-18

Fasting

- and **your Father** ... he will fully **reward** you.

Matthew 6:19-21

Conclusion

- ¹⁹ Don't store up **treasures** for yourself on the land,
where moth and rust disfigure,
and where thieves can break in and steal.
- ²⁰ Rather, store up for yourselves **treasure** in the sky,
where neither moth nor rust can disfigure,
and where thieves can't break in and steal.
- ²¹ Because wherever your **treasure** is,
there your heart will be also.

Matthew 6:1-21. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

The opening statement in 6:1 links back to Jesus' description of his disciples as the salt and light of the world, and this creates an interesting interplay.

Matthew 5:14-6:1 Instructor's Translation

¹⁴ You all are the light of the world.

A city that is set up on a hill isn't able to be hidden,

¹⁵ and people don't light a candle and place it under a basket.

Rather, upon a candle stand,

and it will give light to everyone in the house.

¹⁶ In the same way, **let your light shine before people (*emprosthen ton anthropon*)**,

so that they can see your good works,

and so they can give **honor** to **your Father** **in the skies**.

^{6:1} Be careful, that you **don't do your righteousness front of people (*emprosthen ton anthropon*)**,

for the purpose of being seen by them.

If you do, you will have no **reward** from **your Father** **in the skies**.

Jesus opens this new movement on the "greater righteousness," introduced in 5:20, with a productive tension that recalls his description of the Kingdom communities from 5:16.

The repeated phrase "in front of/before people" (*emprosthen ton anthropon*) in both texts raises a tension: Jesus' followers are supposed to demonstrate an alternate set of values to their neighbors precisely through their publicly visible behavior. However, that responsibility comes with a liability, namely, the human desire for honor and notoriety can corrupt one's righteousness. And no one else will ever know it, except for God.

"Jesus' statement puts us in a quandary: good acts, acts of righteousness and justice, have to have a public impact since, as salt and light, the disciples necessarily relate to the lives of others. How then can people avoid practicing their piety before others? ... If the practice is based in justice, that's fine; if it's based on self-interest, 'in order to be seen by others,' then it is not. As Jesus did with the 'extensions,' he is looking not only at the action but also the motive behind it. When motive and action work in harmony, when the head is aligned with the heart, then a disciple is moving in the direction of 'completion,' or 'perfection.'"

Levine, Amy-Jill (2020). [*The Sermon on the Mount: A Beginners Guide to the Kingdom of Heaven*](#). Abingdon Press. 55.

Notice that the thesis in 6:1 begins with a negative image of people doing right by God in ways that attract public attention. Jesus brings in the language of “reward” at this point. As the examples will make clear, it is right and good to trust that one’s devotion to God will generate a future benefit. The problem is that religious communities tend to relocate those benefits into the present, which creates a desire to be publicly visible in one’s acts of religious devotion. In contrast, Jesus wants his followers to focus on the benefits that are given not by people, but by his heavenly Father. And if his realm is in the skies (6:1), then so also the future reward will be in the sky realm (as in 6:19-21).

The “treasure in the sky” does not mean that one has to “go to heaven” to get the treasure. Rather, heaven is an ever-present but often hidden reality, the most true reality that there is. To say one’s “treasure” is in heaven is to say that it exists in a more real dimension of reality than we can comprehend. And even more, it means that one day, when heaven and earth are reunited, what Jesus calls the “rebirth of all things” (see Matt. 19:28), then one’s real rewards will be revealed.

The famous saying about “treasures in heaven” is, in fact, a conclusion to this entire sequence of thought. The “treasures,” when understood in this context, are an image for the welcome reception and honor one will receive upon arriving in the new creation.

Jesus has here selected three of the primary ways that faithful Israelites expressed their devotion to God in the 1st century. The list is not exhaustive, as if these are the only three ways a person can honor God. Rather, these three examples are offering ethical wisdom in that they all share a core portrayal of what genuine religious devotion, a genuine “doing right by God,” looks like. The illustrations become wisdom that can guide Jesus’ followers to consider other aspects of religious devotion that Jesus doesn’t mention.

Example #1—Generosity

- a ¹ Be careful about **your doing-what-is-right**;
b **don’t do it in front of people**,
c **for the purpose** of being seen by them .

- d If you do,
you will have no **reward**
from **your Father in the skies** .

- a' ² So then, **when you do acts of generous giving**,
b' **don’t** signal with a trumpet before you,
like the hypocrites do
in the gathering places and alleyways ,
c' **in order that** they can be honored by people.

- d' Truly, I tell you:
they have fully received their **reward** .

a" 3 But **when you're doing generous giving,**
b" **don't let your left hand know what your right hand does,**
c" 4 **so that your generous giving can be in hiddenness,**

d" and **your Father** who sees what is **in hiddenness,**
he will fully **repay** you.

Matthew 6:1-4. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

The first example is a classic expression of Jewish devotion to God, which, as it turns out, is entirely aimed at other people. This tight connection between “righteousness” toward God and toward the poor is a unique emphasis of the Jewish-Christian tradition.

The Greek word *eleemosunen* (ἐλεημοσύνην, “generous giving”) comes from the root *eleeo*, “to show mercy, to demonstrate concern,” and was associated with concrete acts of kindness, generosity, and benevolence to people in need.

In Jewish Greek, it became a close synonym of righteousness, and such service to the poor was assumed to be not just an act of kindness, but a necessary demonstration of an Israelite’s loyalty to God.

Proverbs 14:31 Instructor's Translation

He who oppresses the poor taunts his maker,
but he who is gracious to the needy honors him.

Notice the equation between the poor and Yahweh. Generosity to one is an expression of generosity to the other. They are not different things.

Proverbs 19:17 Instructor's Translation

The one who shows kindness to the poor,
that one lends to Yahweh,
he [Yahweh] will repay him his reward.

Proverbs 19:17 Septuagint/LXX

The one who shows kindness (*eleeo*) to the poor,
that one lends to God,
according to his gift, he will repay him.

“The one who gives generously to the destitute figuratively gives a loan to the Lord presumably because the Lord’s honor is tied up with the poor for he made them and they too are his image (14:31; 17:5; 22:2). Their just and gracious Creator takes it upon himself to assume their indebtedness and so he will repay the lender in full.”

Waltke, Bruce K. (2005). [*The Book Of Proverbs: Chapters 15–31 \(The New International Commentary on the Old Testament\)*](#). Eerdmans. 111.

This also makes sense of why righteousness has its natural expression in assistance for the poor in the Hebrew Bible.

Job 29:14–16 Instructor's Translation

I put on **righteousness**, and it clothed me;
my **justice** was like a robe and a turban.
I was eyes to the blind
and feet to the lame.
I was a father to the needy,
and I investigated the case which I did not know.

Job 31:16–22 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ If I have denied the desires of the poor or let the eyes of the widow grow weary,
¹⁷ if I have kept my bread to myself, not sharing it with the fatherless—
¹⁸ but from my youth I reared them as a father would, and from my birth I guided the widow—
¹⁹ if I have seen anyone perishing for lack of clothing, or the needy without garments,
²⁰ and their hearts did not bless me for warming them with the fleece from my sheep,
²¹ if I have raised my hand against the fatherless, knowing that I had influence in court,
²² then let my arm fall from the shoulder, let it be broken off at the joint.

Bruce Waltke, in an exhaustive study of *tsedeq* and *mishpat* in the Prophets and Proverbs, offers this summary:

“The righteous are those who are willing to disadvantage themselves to the advantage of their community; the wicked are those who are willing to disadvantage the community to advantage themselves.”

Waltke, Bruce K. (2004). [*The Book Of Proverbs: Chapters 1-15 \(The New International Commentary on the Old Testament\)*](#). Eerdmans. 96.

Jesus is, of course, fully endorsing and expressing this same view, though he warns his followers that one's generosity can be corrupted by the introduction of self-interest and a desire for public honor.

In Jesus' day, as in our own, public acts of generosity were the primary way a person increased their public status and honor. This honor could then be used as leverage over against others as one climbed the ladder of status and prestige.

Luke 7:1–5 Instructor's Translation

When Jesus had finished saying all this to the people who were listening, he entered Capernaum.
There a centurion's servant, whom his master valued highly, was sick and about to die.
The centurion heard of Jesus and sent some elders of the Jews to him, asking him to come and heal his servant. When they came to Jesus, they pleaded earnestly with him, “This man deserves to have you do this, because he loves our nation and has built our synagogue.”

The earliest synagogue inscription is a memorial plaque for the building's donor.



Zeigarnik, Andrey (2019). [Wikipedia](#).

This is Jesus' first use of the word "hypocrite" (Greek: *hypokrites*), and notice it does NOT mean 'saying one thing and doing another.' Rather, it describes doing the right thing with the wrong motive and desire.

Example #2—Prayer

a ⁵ And **when you pray**,
don't be **like the hypocrites**,

A

b **because they** love to **pray**
while standing in the gathering places and at the corners of wide streets,
for the purpose of **being visible to people** .

c Truly, I tell you: They have fully received their **reward** .

a' ⁶ But **you, when you pray**,

B

b' **enter into your inner-room and shut the door,**
so you can **pray** to **your Father** **in hiddenness** ,

c' and **your Father** , **who sees** what is **in hiddenness** ,
he will fully **reward** you.

a" ⁷ And **when you are praying**,
don't use meaningless repetition **like the nations**,

A' b" **because they** suppose
that they'll be heard on account of their many words.

c" 8 So don't be like them,
because **your Father** knows what you need
before you even ask him.

9 Therefore, **when you pray**, do it this way:

a **Our Father** who is **in the skies**,
may your name be recognized as sacred,

b 10 **may your kingdom** come,
and may your will be done,

a' as it is **in the skies**,
so also **on the land**.

a 11 Our daily provision of bread,
b give to us today.

a' 12 And forgive us our debts,
b' just as we also have forgiven those indebted to us.

a" 13 And don't lead us to be tested,
b" but deliver us from the evil one.

a 14 For if you **forgive** people their transgressions,
b **your Father in the skies** will also **forgive** you.

a' 15 But if you will not **forgive** people,
b' then neither will **your Father** **forgive** your transgressions.

Matthew 6:5-15. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Prayer was woven into the life of God's people, and was one of the key ways they "did right by God," through the practice of honoring him for his generosity and many gifts (praise) and through calling out to him for help and deliverance (requests and intercession).

In Jesus' day, prayer was a spontaneous expression of connection to God, and also structured as a fixed rhythm of life. There are hints within the Hebrew Bible that Israelite prayer liturgies took place in the morning, afternoon, and evening.

Psalms 55:16–17 Instructor's Translation

As for me, I call to God, and the Lord saves me.
Evening, morning and noon I cry out in distress, and he hears my voice.

Daniel 6:10 Instructor's Translation

Now when Daniel learned that the decree had been published, he went home to his upstairs room where the windows opened toward Jerusalem. Three times a day he got down on his knees and prayed, giving thanks to his God, just as he had done before.

Acts 2:42 Instructor's Translation

They were continually devoting themselves to the apostles' teaching and to fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to **the prayers**.

Acts 3:1 Instructor's Translation

One day Peter and John were going up to the temple at the time of prayer—at three in the afternoon.

In the period of the exile, we begin to see mention of prayer rhythms three times a day. And if one happened to be out in public, then one's prayer time became a very visible and public reality. This is still common in many cultures today.

"Heard Because of Their Many Words ... Meaningless Repetition"

"Meaningless repetition" is the Greek *battologeo* (βατταλογέω).

There is debate over the origin and meaning of this word, which is paired with "many-words" (*polulogia*).

- "to stutter, or speak in a way that repeats the same words over and over again without thinking." ([BDAG](#))
- Used outside the New Testament, this Greek root is used to describe a speech impediment (*battos*, see Liddell-Scott on βάττος).

"At least three explanations of [this word's] etymology have been offered. It is impossible to decide between them. (1) It might be a hybrid form, deriving from the Aramaic *bāṭēl* ('empty, inane') + λόγος (cf. BDF § 40, citing Blass; see sys.h). *bāṭēl* appears in an Aramaic papyrus from Murabba't with the meaning of ineffectual; see Mur 25a 1:7. Also from the Semitic sphere is the Hebrew *bāṭā* = 'speak rashly, thoughtlessly' (Lev. 5:4; Ps. 106:33). (2) According to Schlatter (p. 206), the non-literary word refers to the futility of gathering bramble twigs and thus to futile exertion in general. βάτος = 'bramble' and λέγειν can mean 'to gather'. (3) In the opinion of G. Delling (TWNT 1, p. 598) βατταλογέω was simply formulated on the analogy of the better known βατταρίζω (= 'stammer, stutter') in connection with -λογεῖν."

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)](#). T&T Clark International. 587-588.

It is possible that Jesus is tapping into a tradition with roots in the Hebrew Bible, about prayer that is frank, not adorned with fancy vocabulary and long-form rhetorical flourish:

Ecclesiastes 5:2 LEB

Do not be rash with your mouth, and do not let your heart be quick to utter a word before God. For God is in heaven, and you are on earth; therefore, let your words be few.

Sirach 7:14 NRSVCE

Do not babble in the assembly of the elders, and do not repeat yourself when you pray.

There are places where unnecessarily long or repetitive prayers come in for critique in the biblical tradition.

1 Kings 18:26 NASB

Then [the prophets of Baal] took the ox which was given them and they prepared it and called on the name of Baal from morning until noon saying, "O Baal, answer us." But there was no voice and no one answered. And they leaped about the altar which they made.

Acts 19:34 NASB

But when they recognized that he was a Jew, a single outcry arose from them all as they shouted for about two hours, "Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!"

It is not "long-winded prayers that are criticized as such. Rather they are criticized as a means of gaining a hearing with God. The parallel rationale in v. 8b* repeats this scope: the central theme of this saying is not a prayer's length but whether it is heard. Long prayers are not necessary, because God knows what people need before they even ask. The issue is not simply preventing manipulation, nor is it that God knows everything anyway and that prayer is no longer necessary at all; it is that God in his love is with people before they pray and thus relieves them of the need to pray long-winded prayers."

Luz, Ulrich (2007). [*Matthew 1-7: A Commentary \(Hermeneia\)*](#). Augsburg Fortress Publishing. 306.

"Jesus has Gentiles in mind with their piling up of the names of their gods. Sometimes the Gentiles seemed to be hoping a god would be awake or listening—and it is not wrong here to humanize these gods because that is how they come off in texts like *The Iliad* and *The Odyssey*. Catullus wrote a poem about the goddess Diana; the fourth line from the end perfectly illustrates the problem Jesus sees in Gentile prayers (put in italics):

*Under Diana's protection,
we pure girls, and boys:
we pure boys, and girls,
we sing of Diana.
O, daughter of Latona,
greatest child of great Jove,
whose mother gave birth
near the Delian olive,
mistress of mountains
and the green groves,
the secret glades,
and the sounding streams:
you, called Juno Lucina
in childbirth's pains,*

*you, called all-powerful Trivia
and Luna, of counterfeit daylight.
Your monthly passage
measures the course of the year,
you fill the rustic farmer's
roof with good crops.
Take whatever sacred name
pleases you, be a sweet help
to the people of Rome,
as you have been of old.*

Jesus' observation about Gentile prayer is common in Judaism: "do not keep on babbling like pagans." The Greek word behind our "babble" is a bit of a mystery when it comes to its origins, but that Greek word (battalogēō) creates the impression of mindless babbling. At the end of this verse the words "many words" (polylogia) is used, and it permits us to combine it with "babble" to see Jesus' criticism directed at a nonstop prattling in the presence of God. Jesus focuses on intent. The pagan intent is the belief that if they are long-winded or pray long enough or if they show their sincerity by going on and on, God will hear them. Pushing Gentile anxiety in prayer was the offendability and capriciousness of the gods. Jesus teaches the goodness and love of God, here speaking of God's loving care of all (5:43–48) and calling God "Father."

Contrary to pagan perceptions of who God is, Jesus' Father knows needs before God's people ask. Perhaps this idea is from one of the predictions about the new heavens and the new earth from Isaiah 65:24:
Before they call I will answer;
while they are still speaking I will hear.

This does not say the Father knows what they will ask before they ask but that the Father knows their needs before they make them known. Jesus' intent is not to discourage his followers from petitioning the Father but from thinking they can manipulate or cajole God. This means that the major intent of the Lord's Prayer is to reveal a short prayer in contradiction to the long prayers of the pagans. Few prayers say so much in such few words, but good examples of "short" prayers can be found in the Psalms, none perhaps more notable than Psalm 23."

McKnight, Scot (2013). [*Sermon on the Mount \(The Story of God Bible Commentary\)*](#). Zondervan. 171-172.

Example #3—Fasting

A ¹⁶ And **when you fast**, don't look gloomy like the hypocrites,
for they make their faces look disfigured,

B so that their fasting will be visible to people.

C Truly, I tell you, they have fully received their **reward** .

A' 17 But you, when you fast,
anoint your head with oil,
and wash your face,

B' 18 so that **your fasting** won't be visible to people,

C' but to **your Father** **in a hidden way** .
And **your Father** , who sees what **is hidden** ,
he will fully **reward** you.

Matthew 6:16-18. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Fasting was a standard part of Israelite and later Jewish religious life, and it was an important expression of devotion to God. But what does fasting mean?

Fasting is a whole-body response to a serious and sacred moment in a person's life or community. When a person or group realizes that God was revealing his purposes through a set of circumstances, the normal response is to stop eating for a period of time.

The main misunderstanding most people in the Christian tradition have is that they conceive of fasting as instrumental, an attempt to show God that I am serious about something, and I hope that my fasting will compel him to respond to my need or request.

In the biblical portrait, people fast when something has happened, and that something is viewed as a sacred or grievous moment that requires God's people to stop normal life, to focus on what is most important, and connect to God from a place of total need and surrender.

"Fasting is a choice not to eat for designated period of time because the moment is so sacred and so serious that satisfying one's most basic physical appetite would detract from its seriousness and profane its holy character. ... Fasting is a way of focusing our attention on a serious moment or event in life, and avoiding the indulgence of food makes us remember our fragility and dependence upon God."

McKnight, Scot (2010). [*Fasting: The Ancient Practice*](#). Thomas Nelson. 19-20.

The Sacred Moment Fast

Acts 13:2-3 Instructor's Translation

While the Church at Antioch was worshiping the Lord and fasting, the Holy Spirit said, "Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them." So after they had fasted and prayed, they placed their hands on them and sent them off.

The Grief and Turning From Evil Fast

1 Samuel 7:2-6 Instructor's Translation

So all the people of Israel turned back to Yahweh. And Samuel said to all the Israelites, "If you are returning to Yahweh with all your hearts, then rid yourselves of the foreign gods, and commit yourselves to Yahweh and serve him only. ... Then the Israelites put away their idol gods, and served Yahweh only. Then Samuel said, "Assemble all Israel at Mizpah, and I will intercede with Yahweh for you." When they had assembled at Mizpah ... on that day they fasted and there they confessed, "We have sinned against Yahweh."

Joel 2:12-13 Instructor's Translation

"Even now," declares the Lord, "return to me with all your heart, with fasting and weeping and mourning." Rend your heart and not your garments. Return to the Lord your God, for he is gracious and compassionate, slow to anger and abounding in covenant loyalty

The Tragic Calamity Fast

When someone is sick or has died, or when there has been a major defeat or an outbreak of violence.

2 Samuel 12:15-16 NASB

So Nathan went to his house. Then the LORD struck the child that Uriah's widow bore to David, so that he was very sick. David therefore inquired of God for the child; and **David fasted and went and lay all night on the ground.**

2 Samuel 1:12 NASB

They mourned and wept and fasted until evening for Saul and his son Jonathan and for the people of the LORD and the house of Israel, because they had fallen by the sword.

Esther 4:15-16 LEB

Esther replied to Mordecai:

"Go, gather all the Jews that are found in Susa and fast for me; **do not eat or drink for three days, both night and day.** I and my young girls will fast likewise, and then I will go to the king, which is not according to the law; if I perish, I perish."

Psalms 35:1, 4, 12-14 Instructor's Translation

¹ Contend, Lord, with those who contend with me; fight against those who fight against me.

⁴ May those who seek my life be disgraced and put to shame; may those who plot my ruin be turned back in dismay.

¹² They repay me evil for good and leave me like one bereaved. ¹³ **Yet when they were ill, I put on sackcloth and humbled myself with fasting.** When my prayers returned to me unanswered, ¹⁴ I went about mourning as though for my friend or brother.

Jesus himself fasted for 40 days after his baptism, during an intense period of discernment and testing about his future vocation.

Matthew 4:1-2 Instructor's Translation

Then Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil.
And after he had **fasted** forty days and forty nights, he then became hungry.

Jesus' own fasting echoes the 40-day wilderness fast of both Moses and Elijah.

Exodus 34:27-28 NASB

Then the LORD said to Moses, "Write down these words, for in accordance with these words I have made a covenant with you and with Israel."

So he was there with the LORD **forty days and forty nights; he did not eat bread or drink water.** And he wrote on the tablets the words of the covenant, the Ten Commandments.

1 Kings 19:7-8 NASB

The angel of the LORD came again a second time and touched [Elijah] and said, "Arise, eat, because the journey is too great for you." So he arose and ate and drank, **and went in the strength of that food forty days and forty nights** to Horeb, the mountain of God.

Notice that in the Sermon, Jesus does not downplay fasting or say it's not important. In fact, the Jewish practices of fasting were wholly adopted in the early Christian communities.

In the earliest mention of fasting outside the New Testament, the Didache (an early church rule of life) calls on new converts to Christianity to fast for one whole day before their baptism, and on a weekly basis.

"7:4 But, before the baptism, let the one who baptizes and the one to be baptized fast, and any others who are able to do so. And you shall require the person being baptized to fast for one or two days."

Glimm, Francis (1947). *"The Didache or Teaching of the Twelve Apostles."* [The Apostolic Fathers \(The Fathers of the Church, vol 1\)](#). The Catholic University of America Press. 177.

"8:1-3 But do not let your fasts be with the hypocrites; for they fast on Monday and Thursday; but you shall fast on Wednesday and Friday. 2 And do not pray as the hypocrites, but as the Lord directed in His Gospel, 'Thus shall you pray: "Our Father in heaven, hallowed be Thy name, Thy kingdom come, Thy will be done on earth just as in heaven; give us this day our bread from above, and forgive us our debt as we also forgive our debtors, and lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil;"' for Thine is the power and glory forever. 3 Three times in the day pray thus."

Glimm, Francis (1947). *"The Didache or Teaching of the Twelve Apostles."* [The Apostolic Fathers \(The Fathers of the Church, vol. 1\)](#). The Catholic University of America Press. 177-178.

Interestingly, throughout history, fasting is a nearly universal phenomenon in human cultures. While it plays a variety of unique roles from culture to culture, there are a few constants.

Fasts are often initiatory, transitional rituals (from happiness into mourning, from life into death), and fasts are a response to or preparation for an encounter with the divine.

Fasting has a variety of effects on the human body and mind, which biologists have long recognized. (See the world of Rupert Sheldrake, [*Ways to Go Beyond and Why They Work: Seven Spiritual Practices in a Scientific Age*](#), ch. 3 “Fasting”).

- In many species, including humans, reducing the food supply increases lifespan (in fruit flies, mice, and humans).
- Fasting trains our bodies in a very ancient pattern in human development: drawing upon our bodies’ fat stores for energy, because food supply was often intermittent.
- Fasting induces a state of ketosis (when your body starts burning fat for energy instead of glucose from your diet). Ketosis releases a “ketone acid” into the blood (beta-hydroxy butyric acid, BHB), and is similar to gamma-amino butyric acid (GABA), the most important neurotransmitter in the brain.

“GABA is sometimes called a ‘feel-good’ neurotransmitter, and increased levels of GABA may well underlie some of the beneficial effects of ketosis in reducing anxiety and stress, and giving better mental focus.”

Sheldrake, Rupert (2019). [*Ways to Go Beyond And Why They Work: Seven Spiritual Practices in a Scientific Age*](#). Monkfish Book Publishing. 98.

This all has an interesting connection to the role of fasting as preparing oneself for an encounter with the divine, or creating space for a more intense encounter:

- Jesus’ 40-day fast in the wilderness
- Moses and Elijah’s 40-day fasts before their encounter with God on Mount Sinai
- Daniel’s fast when he was having visions

Daniel 9:1–3 NASB

In the first year of Darius the son of Ahasuerus, of Median descent, who was made king over the kingdom of the Chaldeans— in the first year of his reign, I, Daniel, observed in the books the number of the years which was revealed as the word of the LORD to Jeremiah the prophet for the completion of the desolations of Jerusalem, namely, seventy years. **So I gave my attention to the Lord God to seek him by prayer and supplications, with fasting, sackcloth and ashes.**

Daniel 10:1–3 NASB

In the third year of Cyrus king of Persia a message was revealed to Daniel, who was named Belteshazzar; and the message was true and one of great conflict, but he understood the message and had an understanding of the vision.

In those days, I, Daniel, had been mourning for three entire weeks. **I did not eat any tasty food, nor did meat or wine enter my mouth, nor did I use any ointment at all until the entire three weeks were completed.**

In apocalyptic literature of Second Temple Judaism, fasting became a consistent way that visionaries responded to or invited further apocalypses: see 2 Baruch 5:5-57, Ascension of Isaiah 2:7; 2 Esdras 5:13.

a 19 Don't **store up** (θησαυρίζετε) for yourselves **stored-wealth** (θησαυρούς) **on the land** ,

A
b **where** moth and nibbler can ruin,
c and **where** thieves break in and steal.

A'
a 20 But **store up** (θησαυρίζετε) for yourselves **stored-wealth** (θησαυρούς) **in the sky** ,
b **where** neither moth nor nibbler can ruin,
c and **where** thieves do not break in or steal;

B
d 21 for **where** your **stored-wealth** is,
there your heart will be also.

Matthew 6:19-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Reflection Question

How would you describe the difference between Jesus saying “let your light shine before people ... so they can see” in [Matthew 5:16](#) and “don’t do your righteousness in front of people for the purpose of being seen” in [Matthew 6:1](#)?